47TH ANNIVERSARY

THE BEST OF INDIA

REGIONAL WRITERS

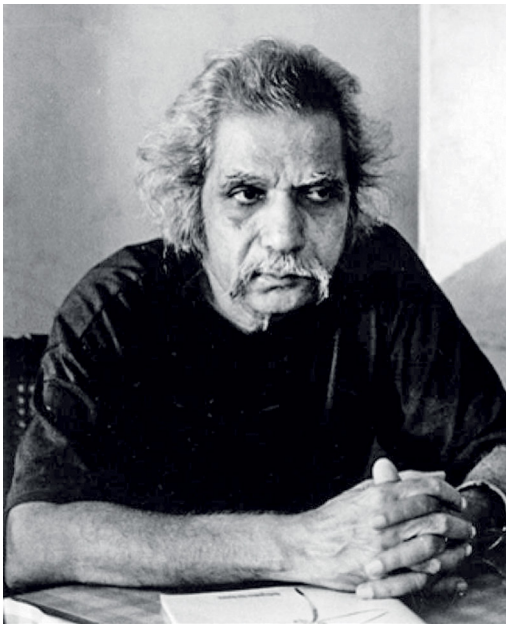
LUMINARIES OF THE NATIVE TONGUE

A polyglot's very personal guide to his own pantheon of writers in some of India's many languages



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To talk of outstanding Indian writers of the past eight decades, choosing them from over two dozen languages except English and Hindi, is like returning from a majestic river with just a bucketful of water. One does not have to state that such a selection, with whatever parameters one makes it, is bound to be arbitrary and quite close to being absurd. India's literary wealth during these decades has been so vast and inspiring that it is impossible to speak of the literary flavour of post-Independence India through sketchy comments on just a handful of writers and poets. Yet I shall do so, knowing that my comments do not amount to literary judgement.

Although following the iconic Marathi poet-novelist B.S. Mardhekar, who brought to Marathi the modern sensibility, Dilip Purushottam Chitre and Arun Kolatkar stand out as the most creative. Both have often been mentioned as being of the same calibre as the most important Marathi poet, Tukaram (17th century). They wrote when Marathi poetry saw a unique blossoming through the work of their contemporary poets Saraland Rage, Grace, Aarati Prabhu, Namdeo Dhasal, Narayan Surve and Bhalchandra Nemade. Both of them were bilingual and translated from English to Marathi and from Marathi to English. Both had gained literary status in English and both were at ease with diverse literary traditions. Yet, their work in Marathi comes across as their better poetic production. Kolatkar's early poems were published in literary magazines and before the publication of the anthology of his poems *Arun Kolatkarchya Kavita* in 1976, he had established his reputation as one of the most important poets in Marathi. *Jejuri*, his anthology in English, brought him the Commonwealth Poetry Prize and his poetry received international recognition in the field of English literature. Kolatkar had also published several other books, including an anthology edited by Chitre in 1965. The bilingual Marathi-English compositions need to be viewed in the context of the historical context of bilingualism in literature.